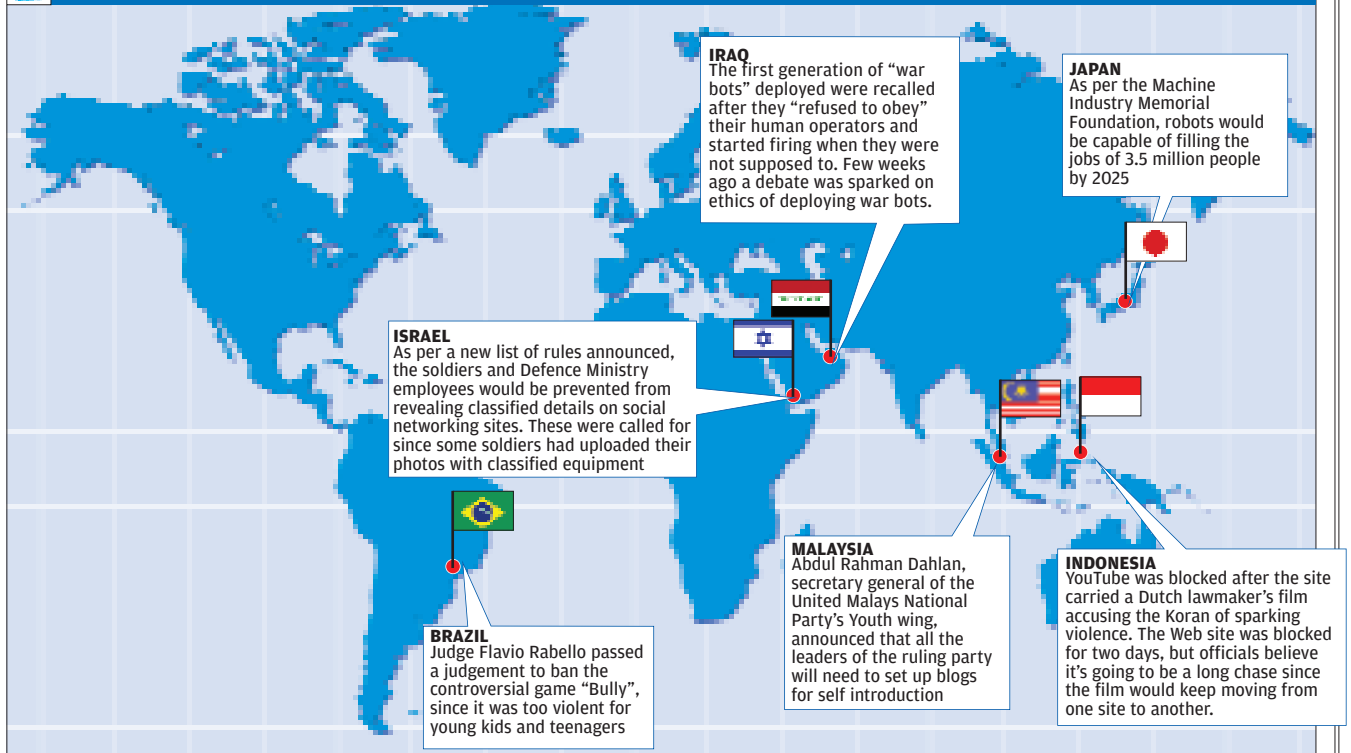




high-k or metal gate, this new material will not replace silicon in the entire transistor, but will be grafted in parts of the transistor that control power and switching, quite similar to an FET (Field Effect Transistor). With this newly developed material, chips can be further miniaturised, made more power efficient and also faster. High-k is a term for materials with a high dielectric constant, which, in layman's terms, are materials that can hold plenty of electric charge. High-k materials are also very efficient, as they can switch between on and off states even when the current is either very low or very high. Some materials with a dielectric constant higher than silicon dioxide used in conventional chips, are zirconium dioxide and titanium dioxide. The name of the new material that IBM is using in the chips is a closely guarded secret.

These new hybrid chips are likely to be used in the new 32-nm chip fabrication

process. IBM and its partners have announced that foundries for customers fabricating low cost 32-nm chips would be available by the end of this year. Hopefully, by 2009, chips with high-k materials would be available to consumers.

MOBILE 2.0

Handheld Blogging

Terms such as "twittering" and "funwalls" are popular on the Web these days. It's the fun way of sharing the latest happenings in your life with your near and dear ones. Now consider doing all this from your handheld or mobile phone! With a range of Web 2.0 ideas like blogging, video sharing, image sharing or audio sharing online, this is a reality. Taking the time constraint into consideration, a new Web 2.0 is born—"micro-blogging" has evolved. But

we knew that already.

Micro-blogs are posted on-the-move using mobile phones or other mobile Internet devices. Twitter, Utterz, JuiceCaster, Haiku, and several other sites have been around for a couple of years, and are now extending their services to the mobile arena.

According to Randy Corke, President—Utterz, "What are the four things you can do with a mobile phone? You can talk, you can send text, you can take pictures and send video. We want to use the technology that you have in your pocket."

In fact, it's surprising that several sites, applications and services based on sites like Twitter are cropping up to add a tinge of flavour to the micro-blogging recipe.

Micro-blogging is meant to be friendly, but can also turn out to be a killer. Head to <http://lin.cr/e5> to read the stream of tweets lashing at BusinessWeek reporter Sarah Lacy's interview of Mark Zuckerberg, CEO—

Facebook, and you'll know what we mean.

Messaging through mobile phones can also turn out to be a cause for concern for users in terms of cost per message and also to the service providers, who after all, have to manage tonnes of messages rushing to their switches. However, on a positive note, this gives rise to new technologies in both hardware and software, what with most hackers turning their attention to mobiles and mobile Internet devices.

WHAT'S COOKING?

EU Panel Pulls On Search Engines

Recently, Internet search engines Google, Yahoo and MSN were questioned over users' privacy by an EU panel. These search engines monitor user